



**NATION
BUILDERS**

SPIRIT OF INDIA SPECIAL

INDIA POST Established 1837

It insures eight million lives and maintains deposits of over Rs 1,40,000 crore. In the world's largest postal network, each post office serves 7,160 people.

MAIL FACTOR

One are the days when runners carried mails on foot from one part of the country to the other. Now wide-bodied aircraft zipping across cities with letters and parcels has become the new norm and India Post, the world's largest postal network, has played a vital role here. Having gone up from 23,344 post offices during Independence to 1,55,204 now, today India Post's focus is not just on transmission of mail, but also developing services that assist, facilitate, enhance and quicken the process of inclusive growth. All the while repositioning itself as a self-sufficient and cost-effective provider of these services.

The coming of Internet and proliferation of websites facilitating faster communication have triggered innovations in the postal system like e-post. A demographic shift towards urbanisation leading to increasing internal and external migration meant that India Post could no longer deliver on cycles. It meant developing a fleet of Boeing aircraft leased from Air India to deliver mail and parcels faster and since August 2007 when the first freight service was launched, the fleet has grown to three aircraft criss-crossing the country.

Today India Post is scaling new frontiers in customer service with Project Arrow which was launched on May 2008 as a bold process of transformation of Indian postal service by revitalising the organisation, capitalising

1,37,508
inhabited
villages in
India out of
5,95,113 have
post offices.



Radhika Doraiswamy 58, Secretary (Posts)

"Measures like acquisition of aircraft and joining the Eurogiro, a payment remittance network, will make people trust India Post again."

on its strength and dealing with weaknesses by sustained teamwork. The Rs 9.8-crore project aims at improving the four core areas of postal service, which include ensuring same day delivery and dispatch of mail, reduced transaction time at counters and also for account transfer/closure as well as settlement of decess claim cases, delivery of money orders on the same day of receipt and provision of web-enabled remittance services. But the going is not all that smooth. Faced with stiff competition from private courier firms,

India Post has been incurring an annual loss of Rs 600 crore. It has identified the need to emphasise on e-commerce, logistics and parcel services to shore up its finances.

A booming mutual fund and stock market may have wooed investors back. But thanks to the depressed stock market in 2008-09, post offices have become 'safe havens' to park investments. The Postal Department increased its deposits in 2008-09 by 16 per cent. India's post offices collectively garnered Rs 1,43,668 crore in 2008-09, which was higher than 2007-08's collection of Rs 1,23,652 crore. With gains like these, India Post is certain to go places. *by Nivedita Mukherjee*